

Mobile watch

A look at what's new with Nokia phones and tablets and interesting news apps for iPads, iPhones and other devices

Streaming the tunes

Music streaming is a viable alternative to downloading online or buying from music stores.

Google+ What we like, what we don't

Google's best kept social secret is finally out. Google+ is out of the blocks, threatening to gate-crash Facebook's social party. At the time of writing this, almost 20 million users around the world are spending time on Google+. The social networking product is still in beta, but that hasn't stopped hordes of online users from scrambling for Google+ invites.

We've been using Google+ for a while now. Here's what we like about it and a list of features that need more attention from Google.

Likes Circles

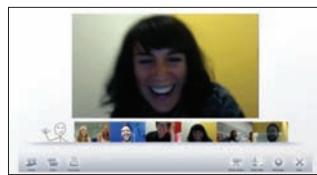
Okay, credit where credit's due - we like Google's philosophy of keeping your friend circles isolated from each other. The ability to share updates with a certain Circle while excluding another is fun, too.

+Hangout

For many people, the group video chat feature, Hangout

is the only noteworthy feature of Google+. It's really something to sit up and take notice of. Through Hangout, Google+ allows you to connect with up to 10 people, including you. Hangout intelligently puts the spotlight on the one who's talking automatically - there's no manual control. It's video chat like you've never seen before.

Facebook tried to counter this by supporting video calls / chats over Skype.



Share - anywhere

For any social product to work, being able to share content with as little complexity as possible is crucial. We think Google+'s one-click share button on the top-right browser bar is a fine example of just that. No browser extensions or bookmarking needed; the feature works on every web browser. As long as you're on a Google product page or service, if you come across something interesting and worth sharing with your social circles on Google+, you just need to hit the Share button.

Sparks

Contrary to user complaints that Sparks is similar to an RSS reader, the service lets you select

the topics you're interested in without having to subscribe to feeds on a web site. Sparks is a good starting point to encounter new content that you're interested in.

No games!

Boy, are we glad about this! Although, there's a lot of noise in your Google+ update stream, we're celebrating the omission of any game-related updates for now.

Dislikes

Instant Upload adds photos from your phone without telling you

Keen to explore the social network's potential on a smartphone, we installed the Google+ Android app and played around with it. All seemed fine. Until we found photos from the smartphone's library being automatically synced with our Google+ accounts online!

We understand that this is supposed to help in sharing the photos with your social circles, and when Google+ syncs photos online, it doesn't automatically share it - which indicates that Google has learned its privacy lessons well from the Buzz fiasco. But sorry, don't do something with our phone's data without letting us know - that's just unnerving and uncalled for.

Tag people outside your circles

Google+ isn't without its privacy gaffes and here's a glaring one we came across. If you thought you were sharing a personal picture with your

Family circle on Google+, all it takes for the privacy wall to come tumbling down is for someone in your Family circle to tag anyone from their circles to that photo or update. Ridiculous, isn't it?

Old threads come on top - unlike Facebook

In Google+, week-old updates and conversation threads are resurrected and brought right on top if someone commented on them. This is unlike Facebook which only shows you old updates if you had liked or commented on them. A little tweaking is needed to at least include an option to decide the behaviour of individual streams depending on user's tastes.

No private messaging

Even though Google+ is Google's social network candidate, it lacks a private messaging feature like Facebook Messages. If Google wants to really dent Facebook's dominance on all things social, it should pay attention to the finer things that make it tick.

No support for Google Apps

One way of assuring a ready, early-adopter base would've been to upgrade all existing Google Apps users on to Google+. We suspect Google is being extra cautious with its Apps user base, since any Google+ deployment there without stringent security and privacy checks might be disastrous to the company's image and bottomline. ■

